HCP 1312: "the Lord God created us for each other", a Hungarian cipher postcard to Jolánka Tóth

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

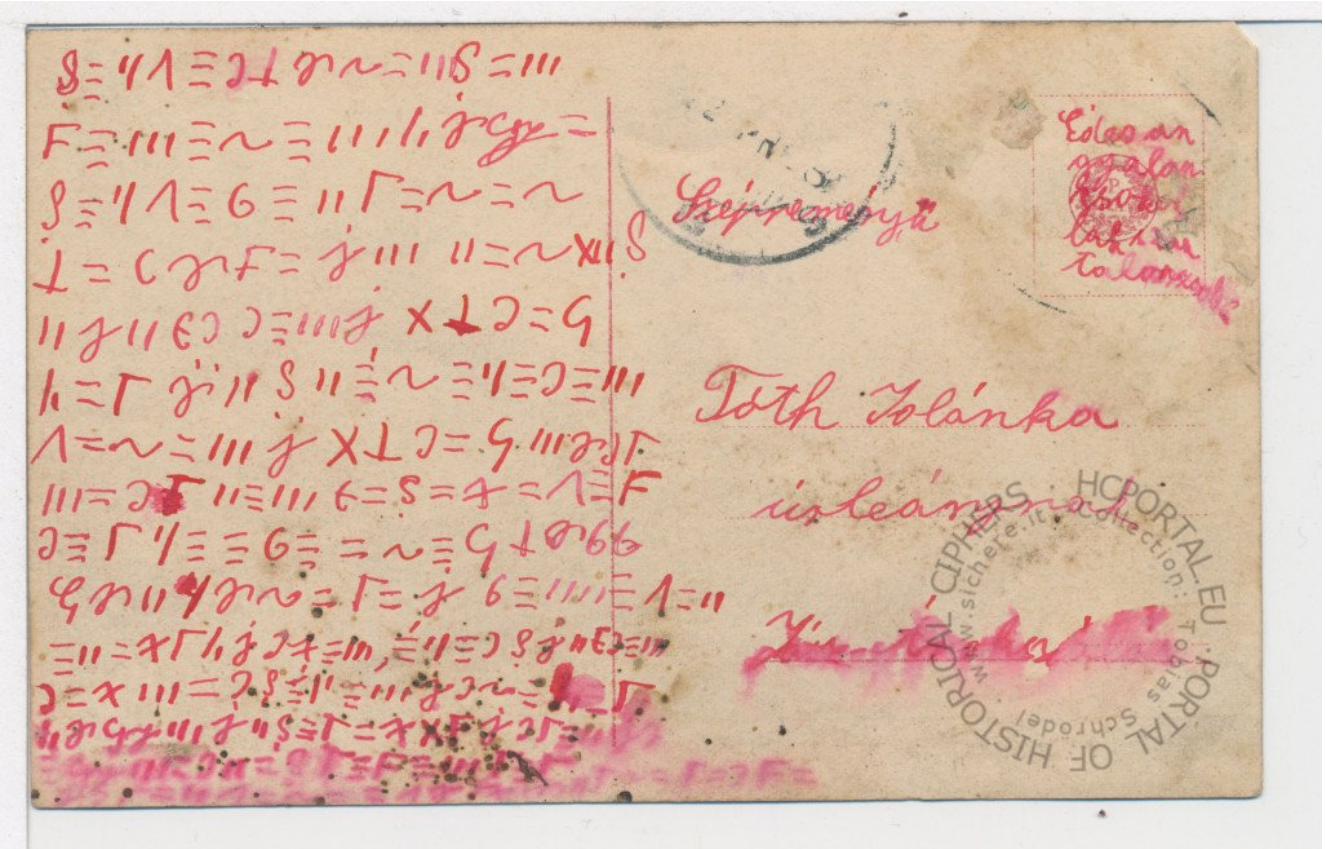
Status: complete reading of all 15 cipher rows (243 signs), with eight signs of the last row restored from context; independent review 1 verdict ACCEPT, no letter of the reading changed. Report dated 2026-11-02.

Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 1312 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1312), portal name cpc_1912-04-_HU__HU_Jasz Arokszalas_jolanka-104, part of Tobias Schrödel's collection of cryptographic postcards. When captured on 2026-10-30 the portal listed it as **Not solved**, tagged Postcard, T. Schrödel Collection, category Substitution, date and language Unknown, sender Unknown, recipient Tóth Jolánka, with no transcription or solution attached.

The picture side carries only printed text, verses beginning "Sirassatok engem orgonavirágok..." and "Csak egy kislányt hagyok itthon...". All the handwriting is on the address side, in pink ink. Fifteen cipher rows fill the left panel, and the last row runs along the bottom edge, crosses the divider and rises as it goes. The ink has washed out badly at the bottom of the card, so rows 14 and 15 are faint. In the stamp box a short message stands in plain writing. The stamp itself has been lifted (a torn scrap of it remains beside the frame, and the postmark strokes stop at the frame), so this message was hidden under the stamp when the card was posted. It reads **Édes angyalom, csók[ol]lak számtalanszor** (Sweet angel, I kiss you countless times), checked again on the original on 2026-11-03, and the address is also plain: **Szépreményű / Tóth Jolánka / úrleánynak / Jász-Árokszállás**. The town line is washed out too.

The postmark cannot be read. The date 1912-04 and the town come from the scan's file name. The card does not name its sender. It belongs to the family of cipher postcards to Jolánka Tóth of Jászárokszállás, Hungary, several of which are finished in this repository (for example HCP 1212, 1213, 1216, 1217, 1218, 1243 and 1301). No identification with a writer on those cards is claimed here.



Address side: fifteen cipher rows at the left, the plain address at the right, the plain message in the stamp box (source/address-large.jpg)



Picture side: printed text only (source/picture-large.jpg)

Method

The key was not recovered from this card. It was **transferred unchanged** from the finished family card HCP 1216. The work on this card was therefore the transcription: each sign was read by hand from enlarged crops of the un-converted high-resolution scan and recorded in a sign ledger, one token per sign. No OCR was used. A first attempt on 2026-10-30 stopped short of row 15 and left row 14 unsure.

The revision of 2026-11-02 made rows 14 and 15 readable with a colour difference. Subtracting the green channel from the blue keeps the diluted pink ink, while the brown foxing and the paper disappear. Rows 14 and 15 then appear as separate lines of stroke groups. Row 15 turned out to be the family's ordinary closing, and the "látásra" that had been taken for the tail of row 14 belongs to it, because row 15 rises at its end.

The rows are written without word breaks, so word division is editorial. Accents are not written either, and acutes are supplied. The cipher does mark ö, by adding dots to the o sign.



Rows 14 and 15 at the bottom edge, unprocessed: the washed area (work/rev2/report_r14_15.png)

All 243 signs fall into 25 sign classes of the key, with no change from row to row. The sum of the evidence is that a family key, applied without change, gives connected Hungarian across the card, and the text refers to the card itself: "that verse" is the printed verse on the picture side.

Key

Simple monoalphabetic substitution with invented graphic signs. Register type (2026-11-03): **MASC + Steganography**, because the stamp has been lifted and a plain Hungarian message was written under it in the stamp box. The labels are conventional names for the handwritten shapes.

Sign	Letter	Sign	Letter	Sign	Letter
two bars	a	long slash + short tick	d	right bowl	s
six	b	three bars	e	gamma	t
left bowl	c	open loop, descender	g	plain cross x	u
opposed bowls	cs	joined loop + descender	gy	chevron	v
tall + short stroke	h / p	crossed dotted curve	i	crossed diagonal	z
inverted T	j	section mark	k	wave	l
three strokes	m	two strokes	n	cursive loop	o (dots: ö)
F-like	r				

The letters f and y do not occur on this card. The tall + short sign stands for both h and p, so each occurrence rests on the word: p in "másképen", h in "hogy", "hát", "hiszem" and "lehet".

Plaintext

Literal decipherment, row by row. (x) is a washed sign read from enhanced crops. {x} is a restored sign, where only stroke width and count fit and the value comes from the word and the family closing.

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01 kedvesjolankam
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02 remelemhogya
03 kedvebentalal
04 jacoraimnalunk
05 nincssemmiujsag
06 hatönkneledesem
07 valamiujsagmost
08 mastnemcakazaver
09 setdeebealegjobb
10 gondolataibennevan
11 enazthiszemedeskincsem
12 sazmaskepemisle(h)(e)t
13 hogyminketazuriste(n)
14 (e)(gy)(m)(a)(s)(n)(a)(k)(t)(e)(r)(e)(m)(t)(e)(t)
15 {i}{s}{t}(e)(n)(v)(e)(l)(e)(a)(v){i}{s}{z}{o}{n}(t)(l)(a)(t)(a)(s)(r)(a)
```

Normalized Hungarian. Square brackets mark a letter the card does not have as written, omitted or replaced.

Kedves Jolánkám! Remélem, hogy a kedvében találja [s]oraim. Nálunk nincs semmi újság. Hát ön[ö]knél, édesem? Valami újság? Most mást nem, c[s]ak az[t] a verset, de eb[b]e[n] a legjobb gondolatai[m] benne van. Én azt hiszem, édes kincsem, s az másképe[n] is lehet, hogy minket az Úr Isten egymásnak teremtet[t]. Isten vele, a viszontlátásra.

Plain, in the stamp box: **Édes angyalom, csók[ol]lak számtalanszor.**

Plain, address: **Szépreményű Tóth Jolánka úrleánynak, Jász-Árokszállás.**

English translation: **Dear Jolánka! I hope my lines find you in [good] spirits. There is no news with us. And with you, my sweet? Any news? For now nothing else, only that verse, but my best thoughts are in it. I believe, sweet treasure, and it may also be otherwise, that the Lord God created us for each other. God be with you, until we meet again.**

Stamp box: **Sweet angel, I kiss you countless times.**

Address: **To the promising young lady Jolánka Tóth, Jászárokszállás.**

Slovak translation: **Milá Jolánka! Dúfam, že Vás moje riadky zastihnú v [dobrej] nálade. U nás nie je nič nové. A u Vás, drahá? Niečo nové? Teraz nič iné, len tú báseň, ale sú v nej moje najlepšie myšlienky. Myslím si, sladký poklad, a môže to byť aj inak, že nás Pán Boh stvoril jeden pre druhého. S Bohom, dovidenia.**

Rámček na známku: **Sladký anjel môj, bozkávam Ťa nespočetnekrát.**

Adresa: **Sľubnej slečne Jolánke Tóthovej, Jászárokszállás.**

Reproduction

From the repository root:

```
python3 -I ciphers/hcp-1312/work/decode_rev2.py
```

The script uses only the Python standard library. It checks the SHA-256 hashes of both source scans, decodes the sign ledger work/ledger-rev2.txt with the key, and prints the literal rows and the normalized text. It does not read the image: the transcription step is manual, and the ledger is the record of it.

Uncertainties

- **Row 15 is washed.** The signs n of Isten, both v, the l, the word "a", the t of "viszont" and the end "látásra" can be seen. Eight signs are restored rather than read: i s t of "Isten" and i s z o n of "viszont". In "viszont", s and z are one merged mass, and o and n were not told apart as signs. The word is still certain, because v...t + látásra leaves only "viszontlátásra". The closing "Isten vele, a viszontlátásra" also occurs on HCP 1216 and 1212, a parallel that helped this reading. Both e of "vele" are faint, and a and e are not firmly separated in this row, so those values rest on the word.

- **Row 15, the t of "viszont".** This sign is not a textbook gamma: its stem rises above the bar and it has a small protrusion to the left. It is read as t because no other value fits.
- **Row 14** is washed, but all 16 signs can be counted. The middle t of "teremtet" shows its stem only. There is one final t and no room for a second, so the writer's "teremtet" is normalized to "teremtett".
- **Row 12.** "lehet" rests on a heavy stem under a blot and three bars in the stain. The word written "másképem" ends in three strokes, the third short, so the writer's m is normalized to n.
- **An odd clause.** "s az másképen is lehet" means "and it may also be otherwise", which sits strangely in the sentence. A "nem" would give "and it cannot be otherwise either", but no "nem" is on the card and none is supplied. The translation keeps what is written.
- **Word-sense calls on clear signs.** Row 4 has a plain left bowl where sense needs s ("coraim", soraim). Row 8 has a barred left bowl alone where sense needs cs ("cak", csak); it is the left half of the writer's own cs sign. The first sign of row 10 is a hooked g variant, g by sense.
- **Writer's short forms.** "önknél", "az a verset", "ebe" and "gondolatai" are normalized as shown by the brackets. Row 3 has "a kedvében", with no "legjobb" or "jó" as in the family formula, so "good" and "dobrej" are supplied in the translations.
- **Stamp box.** The lines read Édes an / gyalom / Csók / lak szám / talanszor, the third written over the printed stamp mark. Faint traces right of the k may be "ol", which would give the full "csókollak", but they are too faint to confirm. The normalized word is the same either way.
- **Address.** "Szépreményű", "Tóth Jolánka" and "úrleánynak" are clear. The town line is washed out. The J, the sz and the accent ticks are compatible with Jász-Árokszállás, and the rest rests on the file name and the family's address.
- **Date and sender.** The date 1912-04 rests on the file name alone. The sender is unknown.
- No published solution was used. The check rests on the portal status (Not solved, no attachment) and the AI Decipherment Register check of 2026-11-02, which found no record for this card.

Review summary

Reviewer: a separate Claude Opus 5.5 agent, round 1, verdict **ACCEPT**. The reviewer ran the reproduction command, wrote its own decoder and its own transcription of all 15 rows, and made its own crops at up to 8x. The two ledgers agree in all 243 signs. This check was not blind, because the reviewer had seen the ledger, and for row 15 the restored signs were only tested for compatibility. The reviewer confirmed that the key agrees with HCP 1216, that the Hungarian is natural and fits the family formulas, and that the picture side has no handwriting. It could not verify the postmark, the town line letter by letter, or the middle of row 15 as independent readings.

Its five findings were all minor and were addressed:

- **Restored signs not marked apart.** The ledger and output now mark them as {x}, and the merged s/z and the unseparated o/n are stated. The solver marks eight signs, one more than the reviewer's seven, adding the t of "Isten".
- **Stamp box line 3.** The possible "ol" after "Csók" is now stated.
- **"good" supplied.** Now bracketed in the translations and noted.
- **Crossbar sign.** Its departure from the usual gamma is now disclosed, after a further crop confirmed it.
- **Bracket convention.** [s]oraim, c[s]ak and másképe[n] are now bracketed like the other normalizations.

No letter of the reading changed as a result of the review.

Credit

The transcription and decipherment of this card, this report and the closing steps are by Claude Opus 5.5. The family key comes from the finished card HCP 1216 and earlier family cards, whose first passes were made by the OpenAI GPT solver.

Sources

- HC Portal record 1312, General, Description and Attachments tabs, captured 2026-10-30: https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1312 (source/metadata.md). The portal cites https://ecp.ep.liu.se/index.php/histocrypt as its source.
- Address side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3997/conversions/cpc_1912-04-_HU__HU_Jasz-Arokszalas_jolanka-104_adr-large.jpg (source/address-large.jpg), and the un-converted original in work/hires/.
- Picture side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3996/conversions/cpc_1912-04-_HU__HU_Jasz-Arokszalas_jolanka-104_pic-large.jpg (source/picture-large.jpg), and the un-converted original in work/hires/.
- Family key: ciphers/hcp-1216 in this repository.
- AI Decipherment Register (https://ai.hcportal.eu/register/), checked 2026-11-02.